



FASHION
PROFILE

If the awards night might symbolise an act of closure on his chapter in fashion, his one in movies is still being written. Ford has proved he has "transferable skills". Big time. His obsessional talent for super-vigilant image control applies to everything he has ever touched, all the way up to big-screen directing. His movies, *A Single Man* (2009) and *Nocturnal Animals* (2016)—which were written, produced and directed by him—garnered great reviews. "The second one," he points out, "had nine Bafta nominations. Only one had more that year."

This was to come as an enormous surprise among the fashion industry. "I only found out afterwards that everyone was saying I was mad and would fail," he says with a laugh. "But I'm a storyteller. I think I did that through fashion, fashion images, stores. But making films is the closest you ever get to being God. Because you're not just designing clothes. You're designing what they do, what they say. And it's forever sealed in a bubble. And fashion is not permanent."



Two new projects are on the go. "One is an adaptation of *Cry to Heaven* by Anne Rice. I've loved it for years. It's set in 18th-century Venice, about castrati [male singers who underwent castration]. I met with her in New Orleans before she died and I've drafted the screenplay." In these times of furore about gender, that sounds like a typically provocative Fordian subject. He's having trouble casting the right young actor, though. He has another project on the back burner—this, entirely written by himself—if he can't.

Ford is astonishing. A little weird—all that insatiable desire to control— but fun and jokingly self-aware of how he can't help his perfectionism. In fashion, designers aren't supposed to be excellent at more than one thing, you see. They're also believed to be terrible at making money for themselves. Ford has proved everyone wrong for 30 years.

It reminds me of something he once told me about being a child, at home in a suburb of Houston, Texas, or possibly Santa Fe, where his realtor parents, Shirley and Thomas Ford, brought up Tom and his sister, Jennifer. "One day there was a ballet on television. I remember seeing it, leaping around and calling, 'Look, Mommy, look. I can do that!' "

It has never occurred to him that he couldn't do something—and that has included becoming a father. I remember another conversation, in the late Nineties, a couple of years into Gucci, when he told me that his biggest dream was to become a parent. "I knew, I knew I had to have a family." At the time it felt like an almost shockingly poignant thing to say—an unattainable. It was years before same-sex marriage was legalised. Gay male couples were not having babies, at least openly. And besides, there was his wild, 24-hour working and partying lifestyle at the time.

Yet this too came to pass: marriage with Buckley, the arrival of Jack, who was born in the States. "I felt all along he had been within me," Ford says, his eyes sparkling.

To wrap up, I ask Ford one final thing: what is his purpose in his sixties? "Oh, that's simple," he says without missing a beat. "It's raising Jack." And with that he is off to do the school run.

Courtesy The Sunday Times London (UK)